Moving westward, China has also sought to expand its influence through what some call the "string of pearls" throughout the Indian Ocean, namely ports and access points ringing the Indian subcontinent and reaching all the way to Africa and the Persian Gulf region.[9] All this has been integrated with the overarching OBOR initiative, as access to strategic bases increasingly follows in lockstep with growing Chinese trade routes and economic agreements. When looked at in totality, the Chinese challenge is political, economic, and military, as well as region-wide; so must be America's response.

Effectively responding to China's challenge requires adopting a larger geostrategic picture of the entire Indo-Pacific region and America's position in it. Drawing such a picture is the stated goal of the 2019 Department of Defense *Indo-Pacific Strategy Report*, which is the first such official US strategy document for the Pacific since 1998.[10] The report opens by stating that the "Indo-Pacific is the Department of Defense's priority theater," which is an explicit reorientation of US defense strategy away from the Atlantic and Middle East. To ensure the continuation of what the Trump administration has called the "free and open" Indo-Pacific, the Pentagon's strategy is built around "preparedness, partnerships, and the promotion of a networked region."

As articulate as the Defense Department's approach is, the demands of acting throughout the vast Indo-Pacific region, thousands of miles from the continental United States, often strain even the best-considered strategy. It is easy to get mired in the tactical and nudge aside the truly strategic. To bring the two approaches into sync, it may be useful to exhume a concept discussed briefly during the 1940s: that of the integrated strategic space of East Asia's "inner seas," or what was called the Asiatic Mediterranean.[11] The utility of this concept will make clear that the geopolitical challenge the United States and its allies and partners face is an emerging struggle for control of the entire common maritime/air space of East Asia. It is helpful to briefly review the evolution of geopolitical thought in relation to this region.